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Officers and elders

Author(S): Teitelbaum, Michele M.

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taa galong court

In Kukaataa, the low status associated with the taa galong's forum results in its being only a court for small money matters. For example, a person took something and never paid for it; or, a boy was supposed to build a trap to keep animals off an old woman's rice farm, but he didn't; or, a man farmed on another man's land and then failed to live up to a prior agreement to share part of the yield.

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The taa galong holds his court under a shelter that is used for storing rice, in front of his house. A loi namu who lives next door regularly sits and watches the court. She rarely makes a public statement, but occasionally she will advise the chief privately on how he has been conducting his court. The taa galong's wife also attends when she is not working with her kuu. She will  97 participate in only two circumstances: if she has a joking relationship with one of the participants, she will occasionally interject a jocular comment about the court proceedings; if the taa galong is listening to a marital dispute as acting klanchii, his wife will often participate as a female advisor. Ordinarily, the group assembled under the rice kitchen serves as a reception committee for strangers and guests in town. Police and government messengers may stop to ask directions or inquire about the whereabouts of the klanchii. If a case is in progress, they will stay to watch and may participate as advisors.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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